

CRY FOR THE BILL BJP Mahila Morcha workers in Patna, Apr. 20

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"IF THE 50 PER CENT FORMULA IS IMPLEMENTED, THE SOUTH HAS NO REASON TO BE UPSET. IN ABSOLUTE NUMBERS, THE GAP WIDENS, BUT IN PERCENTAGE TERMS, IT DOESN'T CHANGE. THAT IS WHAT MATTERS"

PROF. SANDEEP SHASTRI, *VP, NITTE Education Trust*

weight, Sibal said, was exactly the structural advantage the current bill was designed to lock in.

Not everyone, though, felt that the 50 per cent hike deserved to be rejected outright. Sandeep Shastri, vice-president of the NITTE Education Trust, says the uniform-hike proposal, had it been written into the bill rather than offered as a verbal assurance, was a procedurally sensible way to neutralise the anxiety of the southern states. Contrary to popular perception, in terms of population, all south Indian states are currently over-represented in the Lok Sabha. A uniform 50 per cent hike would make that over-representation steeper, while 11 under-represented states from the North and West would continue to lose out (see *The North vs South Battle*). Yet southern politicians maintain that any delimitation exercise must reward their states' success in population control and their higher contribution to national GDP.

The Opposition's distrust of the delimitation engineering stems from two recent experiences. The 2022 delimitation in Jammu and Kashmir, conducted by the Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai commission under the 2019 Reorganisation Act, added six seats to Jammu (raising its share from 37 to 43) and one to Kashmir (from 46 to 47), even though the Valley's 2011 population of 6.89 million exceeded Jammu's 5.38 million. The Assam delimitation of 2023, conducted by the Election Commission, attracted similar allegations: seats with Muslim influence fell from 35 to 22. These are the most visible recent precedents, but then the Congress and other parties have done the same in some states in the past.

Q. IS 33 PER CENT RESERVATION FOR WOMEN IN THE 543-SEAT LOK SABHA A REAL ALTERNATIVE?

The Opposition's counter-argument to the charge that they have deliberately delayed the implementation of women's reservation was blunt and politically potent: if the objective is to speed up the reservation of one-third of Lok Sabha seats for women, why not do it within the existing 543 seats and stop holding the reform hostage to delimitation? One-third of 543 works out to 181 seats. In principle, those 181 constituencies could be reserved for women, with